



▲ **To construct tunnels**, huge rocks had to be blasted. Seen here is a profile marking on a rock before the initial blast.

Unorthodox methods

The Konkan Railway project is considered an archetype of a modern Indian railway project because of its innovations, not just in technology but also the way it was financed and managed. Mostly unhindered by bureaucratic red tape and fairly insulated from the political turmoil of the period, the construction was completed in a record seven years – a mere two years off the mark.

The formation of the Konkan Railway Corporation Limited (KRCL) in July 1990 as a public limited company was a significant departure from the norm, as the Government at the time, controlled all railway projects. The railways ministry took over administrative control while Maharashtra, Goa, Karnataka, and Kerala, as beneficiary states, provided equity capital, and additional funds were raised with the sale of tax-free bonds. Railwayman and engineer E Sreedharan took charge of the project as chairman and managing director.